

Is a Marketing Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The already-in-it guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, and what to do from where you already are.

8.2

AI EXPOSURE · CONTENT & SOCIAL EXECUTION

where 10 is most at risk

For anyone already in it — in the degree, or job-hunting.



Before you read this

The choice is already made — you're in a marketing degree or training, or out of one and into the job hunt. So this guide skips the "should you study marketing" question and goes straight to the one that's actually live: given where you already are, what do you do about it?

It's written to you directly — whether you are the one in it, or a parent reading on their behalf. Where it says "you," a parent can simply read "them"; the moves are the same either way.

What this is. A facts document, not a pep talk. It sets out what's known about where marketing sits in an AI economy, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then what to actually do from here.

The good news, up front. Already in it is not too late — not close. Marketing isn't one destination, it's a wide spread of them, from 5.5 to 8.2, and almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Where you land inside that range is decided mostly by moves still in front of you — chiefly, whether you steer toward accountability and away from pure production. The second half of this guide is those moves.

And one thing specific to marketing. The displacement here is the hardest in the index to see, because it isn't happening through layoffs. Only about 11% of organisations report replacing workers with AI — but three-quarters of marketers now report doing the work of more than one job. Nobody is being fired. Positions simply aren't refilled, and the work is redistributed to whoever is left. The headline job numbers look survivable; the experience of being in the job has changed considerably — which is exactly why steering on purpose matters so much here.

The short answer

A general marketing degree pointed at a content or campaign execution job is one of the weakest combinations we score. The versions that work are specific — and the good news is that specific is still available to you from almost any starting point.

Content and social execution scores **8.2** out of 10. Brand strategy and marketing leadership scores **5.5**.

And here's what makes marketing structurally different from law, nursing or accounting: marketing has no licensing protection, no physical requirement, and no structural moat of any kind. Every bit of protection in this field has to be earned, and all of it sits at the senior end. Which means the work now is climbing toward it, not just landing anywhere.

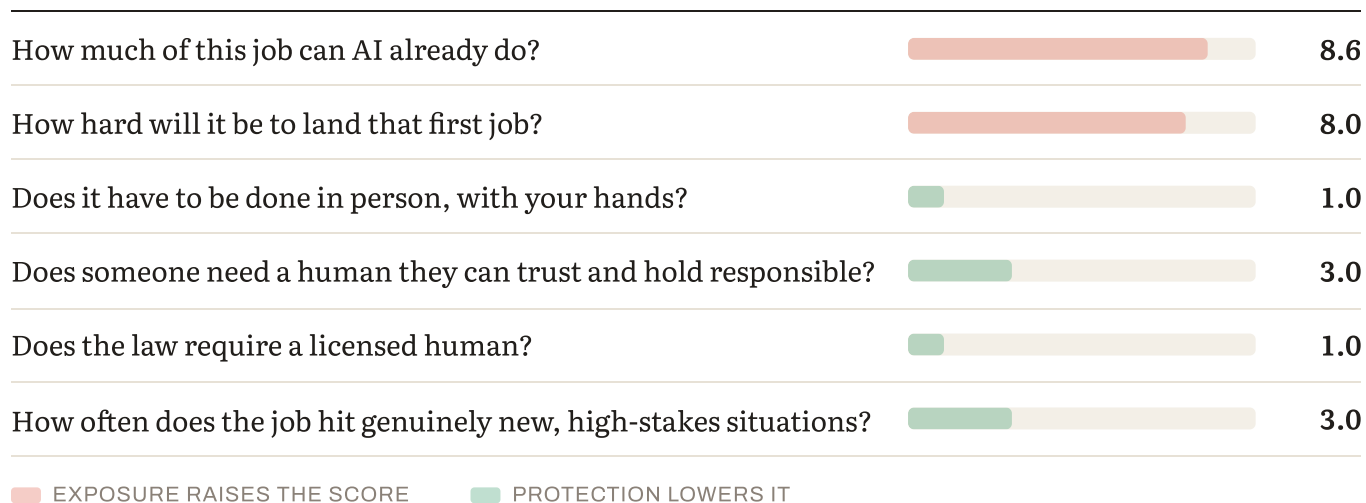
The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Brand strategy / marketing leadership	4.7	5.0	5.5	+0.8	Moderate
Marketing science / analytics	5.4	5.8	6.2	+0.8	Moderate–High
Product marketing	5.6	6.0	6.5	+0.9	Moderate–High
Campaign management	6.2	6.8	7.2	+1.0	High
Content & social execution	6.5	7.6	8.2	+1.7	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, graphic design production scores 8.4, entry-level software development 8.1, and a business analyst 7.6.

Read the table this way: content execution moved +1.7 in three years, third-fastest in the entire index, and from an already elevated base. Your job, from here, is to move up the table toward accountability — not to hope the table moves.

Why marketing scores the way it does — the six factors



Here's how content and campaign execution answers them — the exposed end, and where most graduates start. Knowing *why* the execution roles score 8.2 is what tells you which way to move.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

Almost all of it.

Copywriting and content production. Social posts and campaign variants. Email sequences and landing pages. SEO article production. Basic design and asset resizing. Performance reporting and dashboards.

The distinction that matters is between *producing* marketing and *deciding* marketing.

Generating content is no longer a job. It is a prompt. Deciding what should exist, and being accountable for whether it worked, still is. Those are the things to be building toward.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Severe, and the data is unusually specific.

The Content Marketing Institute's 2026 survey of 644 marketers found **one in three companies reducing entry-level marketing hiring, with reductions outpacing increases by roughly two and a half to one.** Layoffs are up 30% compared with two years ago, and 75% of marketers believe finding a job is now harder.

Meanwhile hiring for marketing roles overall is *expanding* — organisations want more marketers. They are simply forgoing beginners for experienced candidates who can direct and challenge AI-generated work.

The way through isn't to wait for the entry rung to come back — it may not. It's to enter *beside* it: through a placement that substitutes for the vanishing junior years, through a protected lane

— analytics, a domain, product marketing — rather than the generic content one, and with a demonstrable result you can point to instead of a portfolio that reads like everyone else's. In a field with no credential, a campaign or channel that actually grew is the credential. That's a set of concrete moves, not a hope, and the career-hunting checklist later in this guide lays them out.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

None of it. Zero, permanently.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At brand leadership level meaningfully; at execution level not at all.

A board funding a repositioning wants a human answerable for it. Nobody is accountable for a social post. Which means the fastest way to become protected is to get closer to something you answer for.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

No, and none is coming. The section on what a profession has at zero explains why this matters more than it sounds.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At strategy level occasionally; at execution level rarely. Repositioning a brand in a changing market is genuine novelty. Producing the fortieth variant of an approved campaign is not. The distance between those two is the distance you're trying to close.

Look at what a profession has at zero

Most of our worked examples explain why a career is protected. Marketing is worth examining for the opposite reason — it is the clearest case in this index of a profession with **no structural protection at all**, and understanding what that means is more useful than another example of a strong score.

Two of our six factors are effectively zero for everyone in marketing, at every level of seniority.

Regulatory protection: 1.0. There is no license. No professional body controls entry, no statute reserves any marketing activity to a qualified human, and nothing prevents an organisation from replacing marketing work with software the moment the software is adequate. Compare

accounting, where the audit signature is a legal monopoly, or nursing, where scope of practice and staffing ratios are written into law.

Physical requirement: 1.0. All of it can be done from anywhere, which means all of it can be done by anything.

Those two zeros are permanent, and they apply to the CMO as much as to the intern. Nothing anyone does changes them.

So marketing's entire protection budget has to come from the remaining factors — trust, judgment and accountability — and all three are seniority-dependent. A brand director rates 7.0 on trust because a board wants a human answerable for the strategy. A content executive rates 3.0 because nobody is trusting them with anything yet.

That is why the gap between the top and bottom of this profession is 2.7 points, and why the bottom is among the highest scores in the business family.

The general lesson: look at what a profession has at zero. Careers with structural protections have a floor beneath them, however junior. Careers without one have only whatever the individual has personally earned — and a graduate has not earned anything yet.

The ghost workforce — how the displacement is actually happening

This is the most useful finding in this guide, and it is not what most coverage describes.

The Content Marketing Institute's 2026 Career and Salary Outlook, based on a survey of 644 full-time marketers, found something more subtle than mass replacement:

- Only about **11%** of organisations report having replaced workers with AI
- But **76%** of marketers say they are doing the work of more than one job
- And **50%** have taken on new responsibilities with no promotion or pay increase

Nobody is being fired and replaced by a machine. What is happening is that layoffs, attrition and slow hiring are shrinking segments of the workforce, and the remaining work is redistributed to whoever stays. CMI calls it a *ghost workforce* — an invisible labor pool of marketers absorbing the roles of two or three people.

Why this matters. A profession can look healthy on headcount while the job itself becomes materially worse. The vacancies simply stop appearing. There is no announcement, no restructure, and no moment anyone can point to.

It also explains the apparent contradiction in the hiring data: overall marketing hiring is expanding while entry-level hiring contracts. Organisations want more marketers. They want experienced ones who can direct AI work — and 43% report that role requirements have shifted around AI usage even where headcount hasn't changed.

What the trend shows

Content execution: 6.5 → 7.6 → 8.2. Up 1.7 in three years.

Brand strategy: 4.7 → 5.0 → 5.5. Up 0.8.

The gap widened from 1.8 points to 2.7. What is distinctive about marketing is that the execution tier was *already* elevated in 2023 — text and image generation reached commercial usability in marketing before almost anywhere else, because the quality bar for a social post is lower than for a legal filing or a clinical note.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Real at leadership level	Durable	Boards want a person answerable for brand decisions. Commercially rooted.
Judgment under novelty	Real at strategy level	Eroding	Repositioning resists; campaign iteration does not.
Regulatory / licensing	None	n/a	No license exists and none is coming.
Physical / embodied	None	n/a	Permanently.

The honest read. Marketing has two protections, both seniority-dependent, neither inherited from the profession. A graduate has neither, and the route to acquiring them ran through the execution work that has been automated. That's the central fact this guide turns on: the protection is real, but it's earned, and the whole game is getting to it faster than the automation reaches you.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Writing the copy	Editing generated copy, then judging whether it's right
Producing campaign variants	Choosing among generated variants
Building the report	Interpreting a report that arrived built
Learning the customer by writing to them repeatedly	Learning them... some other way
Deciding what the brand should mean	Unchanged
Being accountable when it doesn't work	Unchanged

The fourth row is the real problem. Marketers built judgment about what resonates by producing a great deal of work and watching most of it fail. That was tedious and it was the education. Nobody has replaced it. Which means the people who go out of their way to understand the customer — not just produce for them — have an edge that's about to get scarcer.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Judgment about what's worth saying** — deciding what should exist, which is upstream of all production. 2. **Accountability for commercial outcomes** — owning a number and answering for it. The single most protective thing in this field. 3. **Reading a market that has changed** — genuine novelty, where past patterns mislead. 4. **Taking a creative risk a model wouldn't** — models regress to the mean by construction. 5. **Verification** — knowing when generated work is confidently off-brand or factually wrong.

Notably absent: writing speed, content volume and production fluency. These were the traditional markers of a strong junior marketer and are the fastest-depreciating. If your current value is mostly on that second list, the work is to shift it onto the first.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: **curiosity and adaptability**. The specific tools will turn over many times across a career — the marketers who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious about why people do what they do and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they learned. In a field with no license and no fixed toolkit,

that flexibility is itself a form of protection, and it's the thing employers are increasingly hiring for: the trajectory, not the current skill set.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The industry is not shrinking. Global advertising spend is nearing a trillion dollars, digital marketing roles are projected to grow around 6% through 2032, and employers posted over 376,000 marketing and creative jobs in 2025. Roughly 65% of marketing leaders planned to expand permanent headcount into 2026.

And the AI skill premium is real and unusually well documented. Marketers who demonstrate genuine proficiency with AI tools report earning materially more than peers in equivalent roles — industry salary surveys put the premium in the range of 15–30%, and describe it as widening.

That is one of the clearest, most actionable findings anywhere in this index: the skill gap is currently paying.

What marketers report as rewarding: fast feedback — you find out whether it worked; creative and analytical work in the same job; genuine breadth across a business; and a relatively short path to real responsibility compared with credentialed professions.

Specialization pays sharply. Analytics, marketing science, product marketing and AI-integrated roles command substantially more than generalist ones — and a marketing manager who can run predictive analytics will out-earn a director who can't.

What's genuinely hard about it

The entry tier is the problem, and it's severe.

The workload redistribution is real and under-discussed. Three-quarters doing more than one job, half taking on new responsibilities without additional pay. That is the actual experience of the profession right now, and it doesn't appear in any employment statistic.

Career development is thin. Only about one in four marketers reports feeling very satisfied with career development opportunities at their organisation.

And the title chaos is genuinely confusing. The same work carries five different names with enormous pay gaps between them, which makes it unusually hard for a newcomer to judge

whether an offer is good.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Marketing tends to suit people who:

- **Are comfortable being measured.** Marketing produces numbers, and the protection comes from owning them.
- **Are genuinely curious about why people do things** — not just about the craft of communication
- **Can hold creative and analytical work simultaneously;** the surviving roles need both
- **Are commercially minded** — the marketers who direct are the ones who understand the business objective

It's harder for people who:

- Want to **write or make things** primarily. That instinct points at the automated tier, and it's the most common reason people choose marketing.
- Need **clear structure and defined tasks**
- Dislike having their work **judged by results**
- Chose it because it seemed like the creative option within a business degree

If some of that second list sounds like you, it isn't a reason to abandon the path — it's a reason to steer deliberately toward the parts of the field that own outcomes rather than produce them, which is what the rest of this does.

What else is moving this market

Oversupply compounds automation. Marketing is among the most-taken business specialisms, with nothing capping numbers.

Search referral traffic is collapsing for many publishers as AI-generated answers replace clicks, which is reshaping content marketing specifically — the discipline built on organic search is having its foundation moved.

And a genuinely new category is emerging. AI marketing roles — automation directors, AI-integrated specialists, marketing ML roles — barely existed in 2024 and now command substantial salaries. That's where the growth is, and almost nobody entering the field is aiming at it.

The AI-native advantage — what it actually looks like

Marketing is where AI adoption is fastest, because nothing slows it down — no regulator, no licensing body, no safety case. That cuts both ways: higher exposure, and a larger opening for someone who can direct it. Being already in it, close to the work, is a real advantage here — you can build this fluency inside a live placement or first job, which is exactly where it counts.

And unusually in this index, the advantage here is measurable in salary. The 15–30% premium for AI-fluent marketers is the most concrete evidence anywhere in this index that the AI-native argument is not theoretical.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE MARKETER LOOKS LIKE

- 1. Direct precisely.** Getting usable output requires knowing what good looks like, which requires taste and commercial understanding.
- 2. Verify.** Knowing when generated work is off-brand, factually wrong, or subtly tone-deaf. You can only catch that if you understand the customer well enough.
- 3. Measure and own.** Everything in this guide points at accountability. Anything that puts you closer to a number you answer for moves you up the scale.
- 4. Build the analytics side.** Marketing science and analytics score better and pay more. The people building the models are scarcer than the people running them.
- 5. Aim at the new roles.** AI marketing automation, AI-integrated specialisms and data-driven creative direction are the fastest-growing category in the field.

All five are available to you now — not after some future qualification. Turning them into concrete moves is the rest of this guide.

Where a marketing degree can take you later

Broad: brand and marketing leadership, product marketing, marketing analytics and data science, growth and performance marketing, communications and public affairs, commercial and revenue leadership, agency leadership, and founding something.

The pattern in this index holds precisely: roles where someone owns a commercial number score better; roles that produce material for someone else to act on score worse. In marketing

that distinction is unusually stark because the producing has become close to free — and it's the compass for every choice below.

Repositioning from here

The program-selection stage is behind you. The useful questions now are different — and the good news bears repeating: **almost none of your exposure is fixed yet.** Marketing is a 2.7-point spread from 5.5 to 8.2, and where you land inside it is decided mostly by things still in front of you. Nearly all of them point the same way: toward a number you own.

If you're still in the degree or training

Three levers, in order of leverage.

- 1. The lane is the whole game.** A general marketing degree aimed at content is the exposed one — content and social execution is the row that scores worst in this guide, at 8.2, with campaign management close behind at 7.2. The more protected destinations — marketing science and analytics (6.2), product marketing (6.5), brand strategy and leadership (5.5) — are reached by concentration, not by the generic content core. If you haven't committed to a lane, this is the single highest-leverage decision left. If you have, hold it up against the scores above and ask honestly whether it points at *deciding* or at *producing*.
- 2. Quantitative depth, while it's still free.** The content and campaign roles that score 8.2 and 7.2 are the producing layer — first in line for automation, because generating marketing is now a prompt. The same aptitude aimed one level up — running the analytics rather than producing the assets, deciding what to measure rather than compiling the report — is the judgment layer that ages well. Marketing science and analytics score better (6.2) and pay more; every quantitative module you can still take is a step from the exposed end toward the protected one, and it is far cheaper to acquire now than to bolt on later.
- 3. A measurable result, earlier than feels comfortable.** The through-line of this whole index is that roles where someone *owns* an outcome score better than roles that feed one — and in a field with no credential, a demonstrable result is the closest thing to one. A placement where you carry a number, a campaign or channel you can show actually grew, a small product or society audience you built: **that is the experience that separates the protected end from the exposed floor**, and it's evidence no polished portfolio of samples can match.

If you've graduated and you're job-hunting

Here the title on the offer matters more than it looks, because the most common early-career marketing titles are also the most exposed.

- **"Content executive" and "social media coordinator" are the 8.2.** They're the default graduate destinations and the automating layer at once. Taking one isn't fatal — but take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Aim at analytics and marketing science (6.2), or product marketing (6.5).** More protected, closer to the number and the customer, and chronically under-applied-to — which means less competition, not more.
- **Attach to a domain, not "marketing in general."** Marketing paired with healthcare, financial services or an industrial field inherits that domain's knowledge as protection. "Open to anything" aims straight at the exposed content tier.
- **Chase the number.** Anything with a channel, a target, a growth figure or a revenue line attached moves you up the scale — even small, even at a smaller company, where accountability tends to arrive years sooner.

The AI-native move, from where you stand

You can't undo the last two years, but you can be the graduate who directs these tools rather than competes with them. The five capabilities above — direct precisely, verify, measure and own, build the analytics side, aim at the new roles — are all available right now, inside a current placement or a first job. The most powerful for someone already in it is the third: **get accountable for a measurable number and own it.** In a field with no credential, a result you drove is the credential — and the AI skill premium sits at 15–30% and widening, so the fluency you build directing these tools pays directly. You can start this term, not after some future qualification.

The career-hunting checklist

The analysis tells you where the exposure is. This is what to do about it — the part that's actually in your hands. Most of the protection in marketing is built here, in these habits and choices, rather than handed to you. The first list is for anyone still in the degree or training; the second is for the job hunt itself.

During the degree — build what can't be automated

- **Lock in a lane with earned protection.** Marketing science or analytics (6.2), product marketing (6.5), or a domain pairing over the general content-and-social track. The generic version aimed at content is the exposed lane, and it's the 8.2.
- **Take the quantitative modules seriously.** Analytics is the judgment layer; content production is the automated one. This is the single best predictor of coursework that ages well, and the cheapest depth to acquire while it's free.
- **Get a placement, and prefer one with a number attached.** In a field with no license and no credential, real work with a measurable outcome is the closest thing to one.
- **Build one real thing that measurably grew** — a campaign, a channel, a small product, a society's audience. Demonstrable results are the credential here; a polished portfolio of samples is not.
- **Get fluent with AI as a director, not a shortcut.** Be able to brief it, catch it when it's off-brand or factually wrong, and point to work you improved with it. The AI skill premium sits at 15–30% and widening — that fluency pays directly.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Properly vet the protected lanes — analytics, product marketing, the emerging AI-integrated roles — and adjacent paths before ruling them out. The most crowded lane is almost always the default content one.

During the job hunt — aim, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** Analytics and marketing science (6.2), product marketing (6.5), a domain-paired role, or a route toward commercial leadership — not "content marketer, open to anything," which points straight at the 8.2.
- **Read the title, not just the offer.** "Content executive" and "social media coordinator" are the automating layer. If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Don't grab a job just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. An employer still running a large content-execution intake may simply be behind the curve — and availability can be a lagging indicator, not a green light. That's exactly the rung that gets hollowed out first once they catch up.
- **Prefer the number, and the smaller room.** A role that owns a channel, a target, or a growth figure — often at a smaller organisation — puts you close to accountability years sooner than producing assets for someone else at a big name.
- **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** How they answer reveals whether they're building the job around these tools or waiting to be forced to. You want the

former; it's the difference between a role that grows and one that's quietly being hollowed out.

- **Weigh the trajectory over the starting salary.** A lower-paid role that builds ownership and AI-fluency beats a higher-paid seat producing content in a lane that's automating underneath you.

Go deeper — further reading

- **[2026 Career and Salary Outlook: Content and Marketing Professionals](#)** — Content Marketing Institute, surveying 644 full-time marketers globally in February 2026. The primary source for the ghost-workforce finding, the entry-level hiring data and the workload redistribution figures. The single most useful link in this guide.
- **[An AI-driven ghost workforce rises in the 2026 marketing job market](#)** — the summary of that research. Worth reading for the framing: displacement happening through attrition and non-replacement rather than through layoffs.
- **[Digital marketing hiring trends and workforce planning, 2026](#)** — where demand is concentrated by role, and the projected 6% growth through 2032. Note this is a recruiting firm; read it for the directional picture.

The counterargument — read this one:

The strongest case against our 8.2 is the hiring data itself.

Marketing hiring is *expanding* overall. Employers posted over 376,000 marketing and creative jobs in 2025, roughly 65% of marketing leaders planned to grow headcount, 45% report difficulty finding skilled professionals, and only 11% of organisations have actually replaced anyone with AI. Global ad spend is approaching a trillion dollars. On this reading, our score describes a temporary repricing of junior work in a growing profession, and mistakes a skills transition for displacement.

Where we land: we think this is right about the profession and silent about the entrance, which is why we score tracks rather than fields. The same research showing expansion shows one in three companies cutting entry-level hiring, with reductions outpacing increases by roughly two and a half to one. A profession can grow while its first rung disappears — that is precisely what our entry-path factor exists to capture.

The specific thing we're watching: the entry-level hiring net score. It currently sits around -19.8 points. If it returns to neutral or positive while overall hiring holds, our

score is too high and we'll lower it.

Bottom line

Marketing is not a bad field. It is a bad default — and it is the field where the specific version of the degree matters most. That's the whole reason being already in it is not a problem: the decisive moves were always going to happen from here.

The destinations are genuinely good. Brand leadership, marketing science, product marketing and the emerging AI-integrated roles are well paid, intellectually varied, and growing.

The entry tier is the problem, and the displacement is nearly invisible. Only about 11% of organisations have replaced anyone with AI — but three-quarters of marketers are doing the work of more than one job. Nobody is fired. Roles simply stop being refilled.

And marketing has no floor. No license, no physical requirement, nothing structural. Every bit of protection is personally earned, and a graduate starts with none of it — which is why standing still on the content rung is the one thing not to do.

So the useful advice isn't a verdict on the degree — it's a direction. Take the quantitative modules seriously because analytics is the judgment layer. Concentrate into analytics, product marketing or a domain rather than staying general. Get accountable for a measurable number as early as you can. And build real AI fluency now, inside whatever role you're in, because that's the differentiator this field rewards fastest.

And one concrete thing worth acting on. The AI skill premium in marketing is currently 15–30% and widening — the clearest evidence anywhere in this index that the effort of becoming genuinely fluent pays, and pays now rather than eventually.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one in it or a parent thinking it through, these are the conversations that move the needle now. Read "you" as whoever the decision is about.

Where you actually stand

1. Which lane are you on — or aiming at — and does it point at *deciding* (owning a number, a channel, a brand) or at *producing* (making the content someone else acts on)? 2. Looking at the score table, which destination are you currently pointed at, and is it the one you'd choose on purpose? 3. Is there anything you own end-to-end right now — a channel, a campaign's outcome, a real growth figure — or only things you contribute to? If it's the latter, what's the nearest way to change that?

The move from here

4. What's the single most protected role you could realistically aim for from where you are now — analytics, product marketing, a domain-paired seat — and what would make you a credible candidate for it? 5. If you're still studying: what's the most quantitative module still open to you, and is there a reason not to take it? 6. If you're job-hunting: are you aiming at a protected lane on purpose, or applying to whatever's open? Name the three roles you're actually chasing.

The AI question, practically

7. Of the five capabilities — direct precisely, verify, measure and own, build the analytics side, aim at the new roles — which one could you visibly demonstrate within the next few months? 8. Can you point to a single campaign or channel you've run where you can name what it grew? If not, what would be the easiest one to start with?

Testing it against reality

9. **The most valuable single action:** find someone two to three years into marketing and ask what they actually do, how many jobs' worth of work it is, and whether that role still exists in the same form. 10. If the first offer that comes is a "content executive" or "social media coordinator" role, what's your plan — take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, or hold out for something closer to a number? Decide before the offer, not after.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For marketing specifically, we've flagged that our framework measures automation exposure and cannot see graduate oversupply — and that the displacement here is happening through attrition and non-replacement rather than through layoffs, which makes it unusually hard to observe.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Marketing & Communications

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment}) \end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

BRAND STRATEGY / MARKETING LEADERSHIP — 5.5 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	3.5	4.1	5.4	1.89
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	4.0	4.5	0.67
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.45
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.25
				Total	5.52 → 5.5

MARKETING SCIENCE / ANALYTICS — 6.2 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.6	5.5	6.4	2.24
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.2	4.8	5.4	0.81
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.6
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.3
				Total	6.2 → 6.2

PRODUCT MARKETING — 6.5 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.7	5.6	6.8	2.38
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.5	5.0	5.6	0.84
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.35
				Total	6.49 → 6.5

CAMPAIGN MANAGEMENT — 7.2 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.1	6.6	7.4	2.59
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.5	6.2	6.8	1.02
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.0	5.0	5.0	0.5
				Total	7.19 → 7.2

CONTENT & SOCIAL EXECUTION — 8.2 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.5	7.0	8.3	2.91
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.5	8.0	9.0	1.35
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	3.0	3.0	3.0	1.05
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	3.5	3.5	3.5	0.65
				Total	8.21 → 8.2

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Brand strategy / marketing leadership

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	3.5	3.5	2.95	4.7
2025	4.1	4.0	2.95	5.0
Fall 2026	5.4	4.5	2.95	5.5

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed +0.67 and entry-path erosion +0.15, for a total of +0.8 points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.